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Culture (OWC): [Tonga \(FQ12\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1946-1947, 1948, 1950

Coverage Date: 1945-1951

Place Coverage

northeast-central Southern province, Zambia

Section Title(S): Affinal Kin

Nevertheless, affines are not categorized in terms of their attachment to specific matrilineal groups, but rather solely in terms of the generation principle, in this case traced through the spouse. Sister's husband and brother's wife (both sexes speaking), husband's sister, husband's brother, wife's brother and wife's sister are all equated, and with them are grouped spouse's grandparents and grandchild's spouse. All alike are *mukwaasi*, and they share a joking relationship comparable to that between cross-cousins. Indeed, the term for affine of this generation is interchangeable with that for cross-cousin and for spouse. The husband or wife of a cross-cousin is unlikely to be referred to by a kinship term, unless there is some closer relationship with the speaker, but the Tonga think that the term *mukwaasi* could also be extended to cover this category.

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The *mukwaasi* relationship exists between those who are brought into association by a marriage in which one of them is prohibited from interfering, but where there is a potential clash of interests through the children born of the marriage. When the clash materializes, it is tempered by the long years of familiarity that have gone before. Thus a man has no right to interfere in his sister's marriage, and his association with her husband is one of good fellowship. Neither man can exert authority over the other. Eventually as mother's brother and father of the same children, they may be at odds, but equally the existence of these children forms a common bond between them whatever happens to the marriage.

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All other affines are classed together in a single category, that of *mukwe*. In relations with a *mukwe*, respect and avoidance are the rule. The term *mukwe*

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covers all those who are mothers, fathers, or mothers' brothers of one's wife or husband, and also  59 covers all those who are husband or wife of one's children or one's sisters' children. The relationship therefore includes all those who have the right to interfere in the speaker's own marriage as well as those where the speaker exercises a similar right. On the other hand, the speaker and a *mukwe* are not likely to be at odds over the children of the marriage for the senior affine has no claim to authority to the children born to the junior. Here, therefore, a clash of interests is most likely to occur in the early years of a marriage and grows progressively less likely over the years. The *mukwe* relationship with its attendant avoidance comes into existence as soon as the marriage is negotiated. The avoidance continues through the first years of marriage, and is brought to an end only in a formal ceremony after children have been born. Even then it is replaced by a respectful reserve, though this is least marked between a man or woman and his or her own father-in-law and mother-in-law, and between a man and the person who poured the offering when his wife was first sent to him. The own parents of one's spouse are soon addressed as 'father' or 'mother', and over the years the relationship with them may indeed develop into something closely approximating the affectionate bonds between parent and child.

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